

Spunk

Zora Neale Hurston · 1925

First published: Opportunity, Jun 1925

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_New_Negro/Spunk (revision 15188012), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Spunk suggest about courage and cowardice?
- What does Spunk suggest about the supernatural?
- What does Spunk suggest about community gossip?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Spunk	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*courage and cowardice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Spunk

Focus: courage and guilt in a small community

Content note (adultery, killing, dialect): Sensitive content: Adultery; killing; dialect. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes adultery; killing; dialect.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

In an Eatonville store, men watch big Spunk Banks walk off with Lena, wife of timid Joe Kanty. Shamed, Joe attacks Spunk with a razor and is shot dead. A black bobcat haunts Spunk, who believes it is Joe. At the sawmill Spunk is pushed onto the saw and dies, saying Joe pushed him. The town gossips about who will court Lena next.

Background: Published in Opportunity in June 1925 and reprinted in Alain Locke's The New Negro (1925).

Significance: Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes adultery; killing; dialect.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are footstool, claimed, sixteen, machinist, accusingly. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: ""But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!" In this sentence it means: a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Spunk would have known. Published in Opportunity in June 1925 and reprinted in Alain Locke's The New Negro (1925). Why does this story matter? Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for diction / vocabulary.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: ""But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to courage and guilt in a small community? I circle "footstool", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find diction / vocabulary, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for diction / vocabulary.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of diction / vocabulary. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *"But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'! He rides that log down at saw-mill jus' like he struts'round wid another man's wife—jus' don't give a kitty. When Tes' Miller got cut to giblets on that circle-saw, Spunk steps right up and starts ridin'. The rest of us was skeered to go near it."*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Diction / vocabulary, Characterization, Foreshadowing: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Spunk develops the idea of courage and guilt in a small community. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to courage and cowardice? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about courage and guilt in a small community, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how diction / vocabulary shapes courage and guilt in a small community. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
footstool (noun)	a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person	*"But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks —he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
claimed (verb)	demanded; called for	*Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
sixteen (noun)	the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one	*The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
machinist (noun)	a worker who operates machines	*The machinist come, looked it over an' said it wuz alright.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
accusingly (adverb)	in a way that suggests someone has done wrong	*The men glared at Elijah, accusingly.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
boisterously (adverb)	in a loud, rough, lively way	*The men laughed boisterously behind Joe's back as they watched him shamble woodward.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
skittish (adjective)	nervous and easily frightened	*Tell yuh the truth, Ah'm a lil bit skittish.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
loungers (noun)	people who idle about with nothing to do	*All the loungers in the store tried to walk to the door with an air of nonchalance but with small success.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
nonchalance (noun)	a calm, unconcerned manner	*All the loungers in the store tried to walk to the door with an air of nonchalance but with small success.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage?
2. Where does diction / vocabulary appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with courage and cowardice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23,

24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who is Spunk Banks? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife
2. How does Joe attack Spunk? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: With a razor
3. What animal appears after Joe's death? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A black bobcat
4. Where does Spunk die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: At the sawmill
5. What does Spunk say before he dies? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: That Joe pushed him
6. Retell the three most important events of “Spunk” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In an Eatonville store, men watch big Spunk Banks walk off with Lena, wife of timid Joe Kanty. Shamed, Joe attacks Spunk with a razor and is shot dead. A black bobcat haunts Spunk, who believes it is Joe. At the sawmill Spunk is pushed onto the saw and dies, saying Joe pushed him. The town gossips about who will court Lena next.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Spunk”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Spunk” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: ““But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'!” What does “footstool” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: footstool: a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person.
10. Reread: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.” What does “claimed” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: claimed: demanded; called for.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Spunk” suggest about courage and guilt in a small community? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices.
2. Find one example of diction / vocabulary in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about courage and guilt in a small community? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

4. In the passage that begins ““But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'!”, why might Hurston have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Spunk”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: In an Eatonville store, men watch big Spunk Banks walk off with Lena, wife of timid Joe Kanty. Shamed, Joe attacks Spunk with a razor and is shot dead. A black bobcat haunts Spunk, who believes it is Joe. At the sawmill Spunk is pushed onto the saw and dies, saying Joe pushed him. The town gossips…
6. As the opening story, what does “Spunk” set up that the rest of Spunk will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does foreshadowing appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with courage and cowardice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
10. Background: Published in Opportunity in June 1925 and reprinted in Alain Locke's The New Negro (1925). How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Spunk” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about courage and guilt in a small community? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Spunk”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to the supernatural: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hurston need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the diction / vocabulary in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

7. Compare how “Spunk” treats courage and guilt in a small community with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Spunk see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve courage and cowardice? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about courage and guilt in a small community? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Zora Neale Hurston about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Diction / vocabulary:** look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events

Chapter quiz

1. Who is Spunk Banks?
   A. A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife
   B. A preacher
   C. Lena's brother
   D. A storekeeper
2. How does Joe attack Spunk?
   A. With a gun
   B. With his fists
   C. With a razor
   D. With a knife from the store
3. What animal appears after Joe's death?
   A. A black bobcat
   B. A snake
   C. A crow
   D. A dog
4. Where does Spunk die?
   A. In the swamp
   B. At home
   C. In the store
   D. At the sawmill

5. What does Spunk say before he dies?
   A. That Lena is free
   B. Nothing
   C. That he is sorry
   D. That Joe pushed him
6. In the line ““But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'!”, what does “footstool” most nearly mean?
   A. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
   B. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
   C. a worker who operates machines
   D. demanded; called for
7. In the line “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.”, what does “claimed” most nearly mean?
   A. a worker who operates machines
   B. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
   C. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
   D. demanded; called for

Answer key: 1. A (A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife); 2. C (With a razor); 3. A (A black bobcat); 4. D (At the sawmill); 5. D (That Joe pushed him); 6. A (a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person); 7. D (demanded; called for)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Spunk,” how does Hurston show courage and guilt in a small community? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the diction / vocabulary you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In Spunk, how does Hurston develop the idea of courage and guilt in a small community? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the diction / vocabulary in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Spunk develops the idea of courage and guilt in a small community. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Spunk (where it begins, turns and ends) and its diction / vocabulary shape the reader's understanding of courage and

guilt in a small community. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Spunk suggests about courage and guilt in a small community. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's diction / vocabulary and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Zora Neale Hurston uses diction / vocabulary in Spunk to complicate the reader's understanding of courage and guilt in a small community. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Spunk within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of courage and guilt in a small community responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Spunk alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of courage and guilt in a small community follows or bends those conventions, using the diction / vocabulary as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Spunk and its treatment of courage and guilt in a small community. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's diction / vocabulary and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Spunk as evidence for a larger claim about courage and guilt in a small community in Spunk. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Spunk as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of courage and guilt in a small community. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Spunk.

SAT-style questions

1. *The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.*

As used in the text, what does the word "sixteen" most nearly mean?

A. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one

B. nervous and easily frightened

C. a calm, unconcerned manner

D. people who idle about with nothing to do

2. *"But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'! He rides that log down at saw-mill jus' like he struts'round wid another man's wife—jus' don't give a kitty. When Tes' Miller got cut to giblets on that circle-saw, Spunk steps right up and starts ridin'. The rest of us was skeered to go near it."*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Spunk"?

A. A story told to protect a livelihood

B. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

C. Moral worth found among those society rejects

D. Courage and guilt in a small community

SAT key: 1. A (the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one); 2. D (Courage and guilt in a small community)

Whole-book test

Spunk: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Who is Spunk Banks?
   A. A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife
   B. A preacher
   C. Lena's brother
   D. A storekeeper
2. How does Joe attack Spunk?
   A. With a gun
   B. With his fists
   C. With a razor
   D. With a knife from the store
3. What animal appears after Joe's death?
   A. A black bobcat
   B. A snake
   C. A crow
   D. A dog
4. Where does Spunk die?
   A. In the swamp
   B. At home
   C. In the store
   D. At the sawmill
5. What does Spunk say before he dies?
   A. That Lena is free
   B. Nothing
   C. That he is sorry
   D. That Joe pushed him
6. In the line ““But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'!”, what does “footstool” most nearly mean?
   A. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
   B. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
   C. a worker who operates machines
   D. demanded; called for

7. In the line “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.”, what does “claimed” most nearly mean?
   A. a worker who operates machines
   B. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
   C. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
   D. demanded; called for
8. As used in the story (““But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'!”), what does “footstool” mean?
   A. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
   B. in a way that suggests someone has done wrong
   C. people who idle about with nothing to do
   D. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
9. As used in the story (“Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.”), what does “claimed” mean?
   A. in a loud, rough, lively way
   B. demanded; called for
   C. a calm, unconcerned manner
   D. a worker who operates machines
10. As used in the story (“The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.”), what does “sixteen” mean?
    A. nervous and easily frightened
    B. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
    C. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
    D. in a way that suggests someone has done wrong
11. As used in the story (“The machinist come, looked it over an' said it wuz alright.”), what does “machinist” mean?
    A. people who idle about with nothing to do
    B. demanded; called for
    C. in a loud, rough, lively way
    D. a worker who operates machines
12. As used in the story (“The men glared at Elijah, accusingly.”), what does “accusingly” mean?
    A. in a way that suggests someone has done wrong
    B. a calm, unconcerned manner
    C. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
    D. nervous and easily frightened

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how courage and cowardice develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how the supernatural develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

3. Explain how community gossip develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (courage and cowardice, the supernatural, community gossip) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife); 2. C (With a razor); 3. A (A black bobcat); 4. D (At the sawmill); 5. D (That Joe pushed him); 6. A (a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person); 7. D (demanded; called for); 8. A (a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person); 9. B (demanded; called for); 10. C (the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one); 11. D (a worker who operates machines); 12. A (in a way that suggests someone has done wrong)

Essay assignments

Essay: Courage and cowardice

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Spunk teaches about courage and cowardice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops courage and cowardice in Spunk. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops courage and cowardice across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Spunk (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of courage and cowardice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of courage and cowardice in Spunk. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Spunk (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of courage and cowardice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Spunk's treatment of courage and cowardice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on courage and cowardice in Spunk that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on courage and cowardice in Spunk. Name your critical method,

apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about courage and cowardice in Spunk, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on courage and cowardice in Spunk, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The supernatural

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Spunk teaches about the supernatural. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops the supernatural in Spunk. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops the supernatural across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Spunk (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the supernatural. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the supernatural in Spunk. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Spunk (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the supernatural, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Spunk's treatment of the supernatural in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the supernatural in Spunk that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the supernatural in Spunk. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the supernatural in Spunk, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the supernatural in Spunk, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Community gossip

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Spunk teaches about community gossip. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops community gossip in Spunk. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops community gossip across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Spunk (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of community gossip. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of community gossip in Spunk. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Spunk (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of community gossip, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Spunk's treatment of community gossip in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on community gossip in Spunk that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on community gossip in Spunk. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about community gossip in Spunk, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on community gossip in Spunk, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.